8.2.2 Features of Groups

- The vertical columns in the periodic table starting from top to bottom are called **groups.** There are **18 groups** in the periodic table.
- Based on the common characteristics of elements in each group, they can be grouped as various families.

Group Number	Family
1	Alkali Metals
2	Alkaline earth metals
3 to 12	Transition metals
13	Boron Family
14	Carbon Family
15	Nitrogen Family
16	Oxygen Family (or) Chalcogen family
17	Halogens
18	Noble gases

- The Lanthanides and Actinides, which form part of Group 3 are called **inner transition elements**.
- Except 'group 18', all the elements present in each group have the same number of electrons in their valence shell and thus have the same valency. For example, all the elements of group 1 have one electron in their valence shells ($1s^1$). So, the valency of all the alkali metals is '1'.
- As the elements present in a group have identical valence shell electronic configurations, they possess similar chemical properties.
- The physical properties of the elements in a group such as melting point, boiling point and density vary gradually.
- The atoms of the 'group 18' elements have stable electronic configuration in their valence shells and hence they are unreactive.

8.3 PERIODIC TRENDS IN PROPERTIES

The electronic configurations of elements help us to explain the periodic recurrence of physical and chemical properties. Anything which repeats itself after a regular interval is called **periodic** and this behaviour is called **periodicity.** Some of the atomic properties of the elements are periodic.

Properties such as atomic radius, ionic radius, ionisation energy, electronegativity, electron affinity, show a regular periodicity and hence they are called **periodic properties**. The main significance of the modern periodic table is that it gives a clear understanding of the general properties and trends within a group or a period to predict with considerable accuracy, the properties of any element, even though that element may be unfamiliar to us. Let us discuss the periodic trend of some of the properties.

8.3.1 Atomic Radius

Atomic radius of an atom is defined as the distance between the centre of its nucleus and the outermost shell containing the valence electron. Direct measurement of the radius of an isolated atom is not possible. Except for noble gases, usually the atomic radius is referred to as **covalent radius** or **metallic radius** depending on the nature of the bonding between the concerned atoms. Atomic radius in metal atoms is known as **metallic radius.** It is defined as **half the distance between the nuclei of adjacent metal atoms** (Figure 8.2

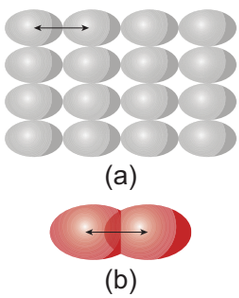


Figure 8.2
(a) Metallic Radius
(b) Covalent Radius

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